

APPLE SCREEN TIME

Step by step, for parents

This walks you through setting up Apple Screen Time on your child's iPhone or iPad, one tap at a time. You do not need to know anything about technology. If you can follow a recipe, you can do this. About 15 minutes. When it is done, bedtime is the phone's job, not yours.

BEFORE YOU START

Do this with your child, not behind their back. Tell them what you are setting up and why. The settings hold far longer when the child understands the reason, and the trust matters more than any toggle. In each picture, the pink box shows exactly where to tap.

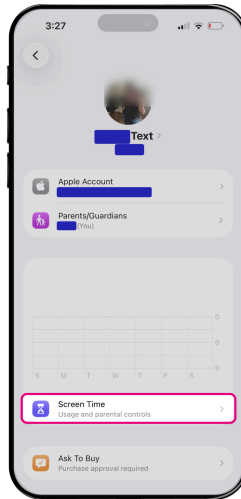
Layer 2 of the Castle Model, the Armour: the controls on the device itself.

FIND YOUR CHILD'S SCREEN TIME



STEP 1

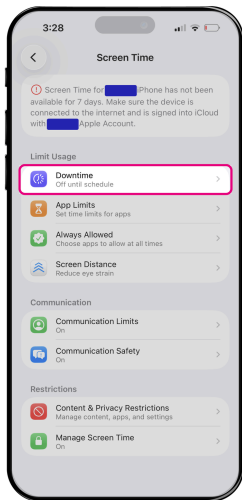
Open Settings, tap Family, then tap your child's name.



STEP 2

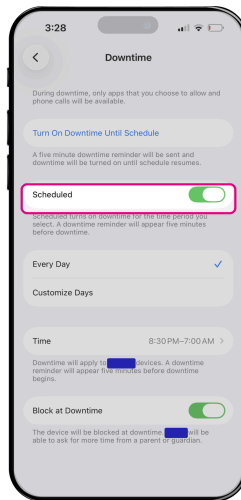
Tap Screen Time. This is the hub, every control lives in here.

SET QUIET HOURS



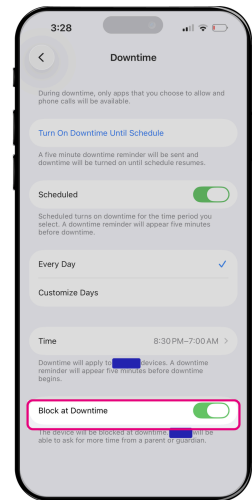
STEP 3

Tap Downtime. This sets the hours the phone goes quiet.



STEP 4

Turn on Scheduled, then set the hours, for example 9:00 PM to 7:00 AM.



STEP 5

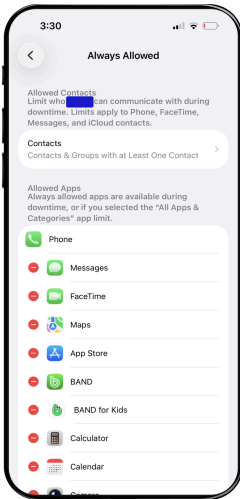
Turn on Block at Downtime. Now downtime blocks everything, and they have to ask you for more time, which you can grant or decline.

SET QUIET HOURS (CONTINUED)



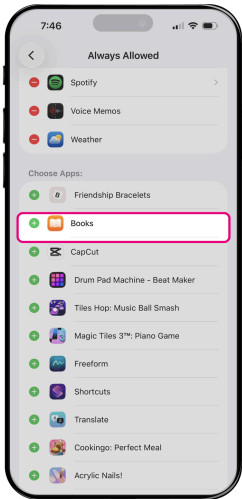
STEP 6

Back on the Screen Time menu, tap Always Allowed.



STEP 7

The master block: during downtime, only the apps on this list run, everything else is blocked. Tap the red minus to strip it to the essentials, phone, messages, maybe one homework app.



STEP 8

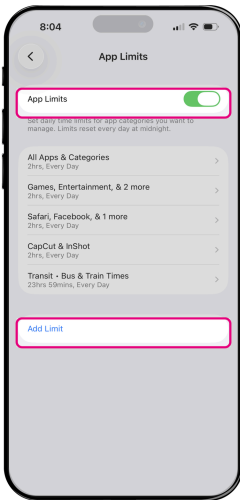
Scroll down to Choose Apps. Tap the green plus to add back anything they should keep during downtime, a homework app, a music app, a reading app.

SET DAILY APP LIMITS



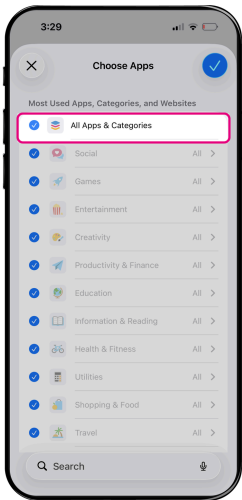
STEP 9

On the Screen Time menu, tap App Limits.



STEP 10

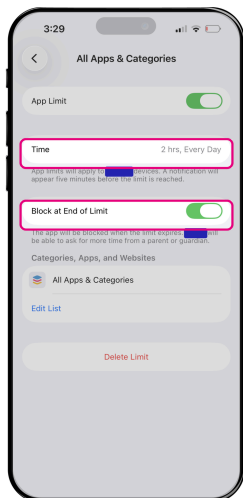
Turn on App Limits, then tap Add Limit at the bottom.



STEP 11

Choose All Apps and Categories, or pick specific ones, then tap Next.

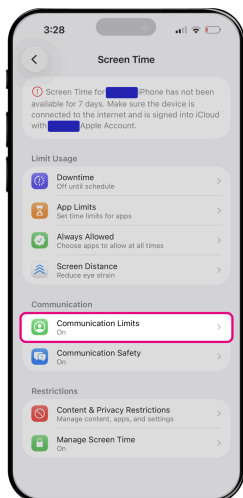
SET DAILY APP LIMITS (CONTINUED)



STEP 12

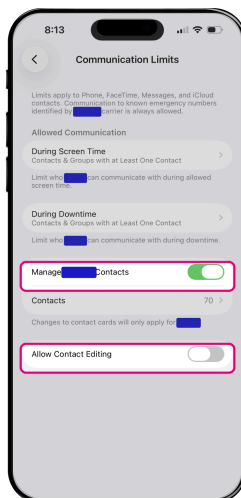
Set the daily time, then turn on Block at End of Limit.

LIMIT WHO THEY CAN CONTACT



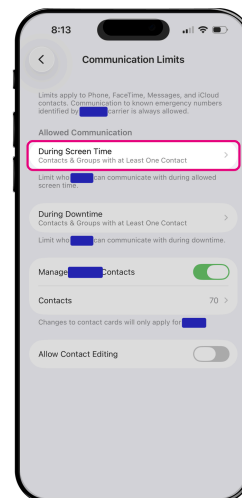
STEP 13

On the Screen Time menu, tap Communication Limits.



STEP 14

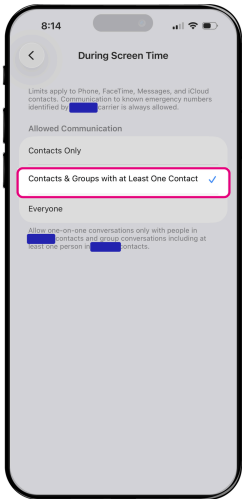
On the Communication Limits screen, turn on Manage Contacts and turn off Allow Contact Editing, so they can't add a stranger as a contact to message.



STEP 15

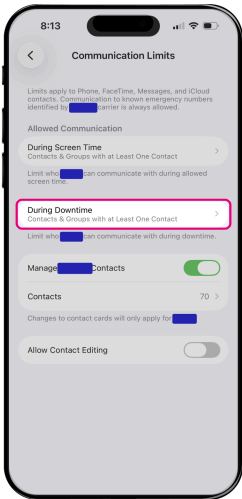
On the Communication Limits screen, tap During Screen Time.

LIMIT WHO THEY CAN CONTACT (CONTINUED)



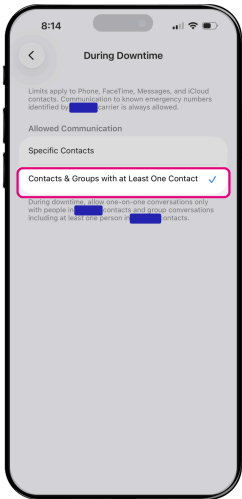
STEP 16

Choose Contacts & Groups with at Least One Contact.



STEP 17

Back, then tap During Downtime.



STEP 18

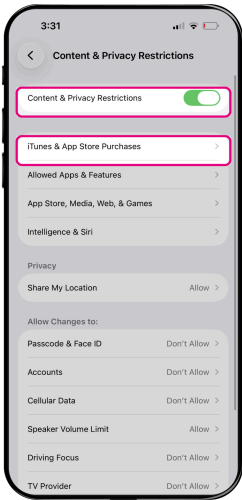
Choose Contacts & Groups again. Apple's downtime limit can be glitchy, but the contact lock you set is what really holds.

LOCK DOWN CONTENT



STEP 19

On the Screen Time menu, tap Content and Privacy Restrictions.



STEP 20

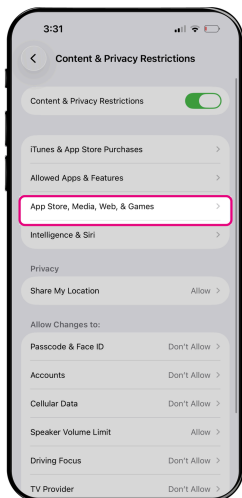
Turn it on, then tap iTunes and App Store Purchases.



STEP 21

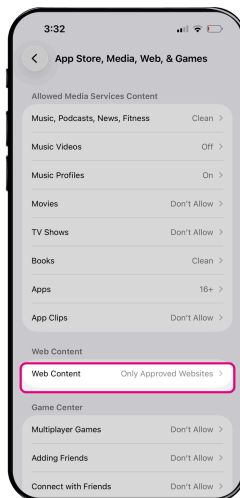
Tap Installing Apps, then Don't Allow. New apps can't be installed without you.

LOCK DOWN CONTENT (CONTINUED)



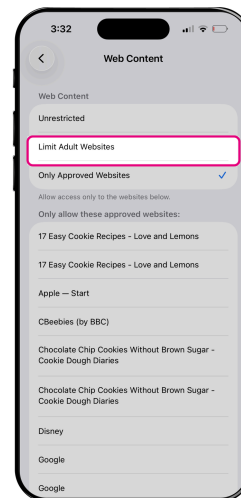
STEP 22

Back on Content and Privacy Restrictions, tap App Store, Media, Web, and Games.



STEP 23

Set the rating levels in App Store, Media, Web, and Games, then tap Web Content.



STEP 24

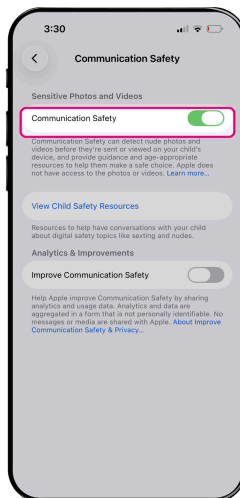
Tap Limit Adult Websites. For young kids, Only Approved Websites is stricter.

SAFETY, THEN LOCK IT



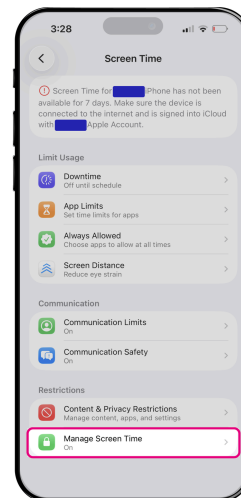
STEP 25

On the Screen Time menu, tap Communication Safety.



STEP 26

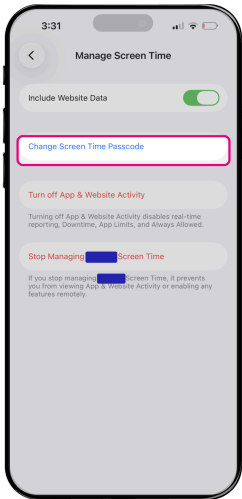
Make sure Communication Safety is on. It blurs nude photos automatically.



STEP 27

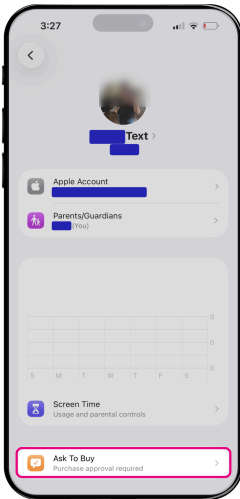
At the bottom of the Screen Time menu, tap Manage Screen Time.

SAFETY, THEN LOCK IT (CONTINUED)



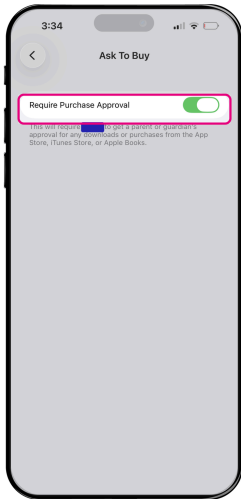
STEP 28

Tap Change Screen Time Passcode. Pick a code your child does not know, so they can't undo any of this.



STEP 29

Back on your child's page, not in Screen Time, tap Ask To Buy.



STEP 30

Turn on Require Purchase Approval, so every download needs your yes.

That is the device layer done. Your child's phone now has quiet hours, daily limits, locked-down content, and a passcode only you know.

WHAT THIS CATCHES, AND WHAT IT DOES NOT

Screen Time is strong, but it is one layer. It catches app installs, daily time limits, quiet hours, content ratings, website filtering, and nude-photo blurring on this device. It does not reach the network once your child leaves home WiFi for cellular data, and a determined teen can still find gaps. The real lock is the passcode: skip it and your child can turn all of this off in under a minute. This is why you layer.

WHAT SCREEN TIME CANNOT DO

Screen Time does not let you read your child's messages. Apple gives parents no access to message content, this surprises most people. The free option is a weekly scroll through their messages together, which also keeps the conversation open. The paid option is BrightCanary (in the Canadian App Store, independently reviewed by The White Hatter), which flags concerning messages for you.

CHECK IT WORKED

Hand the phone back and try to open a blocked app, or change a Screen Time setting. You should be asked for your passcode, and during Downtime the apps you did not allow should be greyed out.

KEEP GOING

This is one of five layers. The next one is your home router, which protects every device in the house at once. Ask me about the TP-Link Deco setup, and put the Safe Family Internet decal in your window so other families know they are not doing this alone.